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# Tailored second innings for old clothes

A resident of Royapettah for nearly 20 years, E. Umapathy runs a tailoring shop at Spencers Plaza First Phase that specialises in mending old clothes

E. Umapathy at work.  
PHOTO: R. RAGU



R. RAGU

**I**n a mall where shops woo visitors with spanking-new clothes stands a rank outlier, a shop that wears old clothes like a badge of honour. Chennai Stitcher, as this shop at the second floor of Spencers Plaza First Phase is called, is not about selling pre-loved clothes, but making those old clothes loved once again by the same owner.

A resident of Royapettah for nearly 20 years, E. Umapathy has positioned Chen-

nai Stitcher as a specialist in old cloth alteration work. The 47-year-old tailor has not sealed the seam on new clothes though; he readily stitches new clothes for people bringing that kind of work to him. But alteration of old clothes is his staple service, old clothes for women, men and children coming within its ambit.

Umapathy established this shop, which operates within a shop selling new apparel around a year ago. Those visiting the apparel showrooms in the mall learn about his services and bring their old clothes the next time they are at the mall.

In his previous avatars, Umapathy had been a master tailor for 10 years at an apparel major and worked in the Cable TV industry for seven years.

During the pandemic, he had been down on his luck, being out of employment, and that adversity sowed in his mind the idea of independence and relative certainty that can derive from being one's own boss.

Umapathy lists among his USPs reasonable pricing, wide repertoire and door delivery.

"My basic alteration price is ₹60 and the



During the pandemic, he had been down on his luck, being out of employment, and that adversity sowed in his mind the idea of independence

price increases from there only on the basis of the complexity of the alteration work. I undertake alteration work that most tailors balk at. For example, when it comes to altering jeans pants, most tailors would undertake alteration that requires them to make those pants tighter, and reject work that requires jeans pants to be made looser. I accept both forms of work. Within a 10-kilometre radius, I offer door delivery if the payment for the alteration work comes up to ₹500. I deliver the clothes by a bike in the late evening hours."

Umapathy's regular expenditure includes paying for the education of two college-going children. Asked if he manages to meet his expenses without difficulty, he says, "I manage but with difficulty."

P. Goutham Chand, a regular customer at Chennai Stitcher, says Umapathy never says "no" to any clothes that are brought to him for alteration. Among the clothes that Goutham has got altered by Umapathy is an old coat. Goutham notes that among factors enhancing customer experience is the fast delivery ensured by Umapathy.

Umapathy can be contacted at 9884541415

## Student innovators to be honoured

Nominations are open for CavinKare-MMA ChinniKrishnan Innovation and Great Ideas Awards 2026

**C**avinKare, in association with the Madras Management Association (MMA), is inviting nominations for the 15<sup>th</sup> CavinKare-MMA ChinniKrishnan Innovation and Great Ideas Awards 2026. This

year's edition sees the reintroduction of the 'Great Ideas' category, revived with an expanded scope to include student innovators. The category will recognise 10 outstanding ideas, a significant scale-up from earlier editions where a single

winner was awarded, said a release. Interested institutions and individuals can apply for the awards by submitting their entries on or before June 22, 2026 at [www.ckinnovationawards.in](http://www.ckinnovationawards.in). Or call 9444700068 to register.

The awards feature two categories: Innovation Category: Open to startups and MSMEs with proven, market-ready products or services that demonstrate uniqueness, scalability, sustainability, and tangible benefits to people. Three winners in this category will receive a cash prize of ₹1,00,000, a citation and a trophy each. The 'Great Ideas Category' is open to individuals and institutions including entrepreneurs, researchers, academicians, and students this category recognises

original ideas with strong problem. Ten winners in this category will receive a cash prize of ₹10,000 each.

Applications under the Innovation Category are open to startups and small-scale enterprises with an annual turnover not exceeding ₹50 crore for FY 2024-25 / 2025-26, while the Great Ideas Category is open to individuals and institutions across India with no turnover criteria; applicants must be Indian citizens or have ideas originating from India, added the release.

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## Mandaveli residents cheer TASMAL outlet closure

The TASMAL outlet on Venkatakrishna Road was a thorn in the side for residents for a long time; the shutdown of the facility as part of the TN Government's move to close 717 TASMAL outlets found close to a variety of sensitive institutions and establishments has been hailed by Mandaveli residents

GANGA SRIDHAR AND  
P. SURESH KANNA

For years, the TASMAL outlet on Venkatakrishna Road near the Mandaveli bus depot junction caused inconvenience to residents and road users due to crowds milling outside the shop, haphazard parking, littering and drunk people entering residential streets. Drunkards made the place completely inaccessible, and women used to face major issues crossing areas within a 100 metre radius of the shop. Residents often felt unsafe and disturbed. One of the best photoco-

pier shops in Mandaveli, Rishi Copiers was located near this TASMAL outlet. It is mainly patronised by students. Due to drunkards loitering around the place, the access path to the shop had been fraught with danger.

With the TASMAL outlet now closed, the area finally feels calmer and more peaceful: a visible effect of good governance. We thank the authorities for the prompt action.

*Ganga Sridhar is a key member of Mandaveli Raja Street Residents Welfare Association and P. Suresh Kanna is a resident of South Canal Bank Road, Mandaveli*



## 'A harrowing experience'

APARNA GANESH

On account of the TASMAL outlet on Venkatakrishna Road near the Mandaveli bus depot, I had a bitter experience while visiting Rishi Copiers in an evening hour a few months ago.

A drunkard held my hand demanding that I give him money for him to be able to buy himself

a drink. I refused and pushed him aside, and told him I did not have any cash in hand. He demanded that I GPay the money. I did not go to the Rishi copiers that day and ever later. The whole stretch was unsafe with people drinking all through the day.

*Aparna Ganesh is a member of Poonga View Residents Welfare Association in Mandaveli*

## RA Puram residents rally against TASMAL outlet

R. CHANDRASEKARAN

Residents of the western side of RA Puram have welcomed the Tamil Nadu government's decision to permanently close 717 TASMAL shops located near temples, schools, hospitals and bus termini. They point out the Tasmac Elite shop at door no 24, R.A. Puram Second Main Road fulfils the criteria for shutdown set by the new government.

This shop is situated less than 500 metres from Chennai High School and Sri Venugopala Vidyalaya School both on Sringeri Mutt Road. The Mandaveli bus terminus relocated to RA Puram Second Main Road is also within 500 metres of the outlet.

Billroth Hospitals is barely



The TASMAL outlet at RA Puram Second Main Road; and locating it on the map.

250 metres from this shop. Many clinics and banks are in close proximity to this shop. Women, children and senior

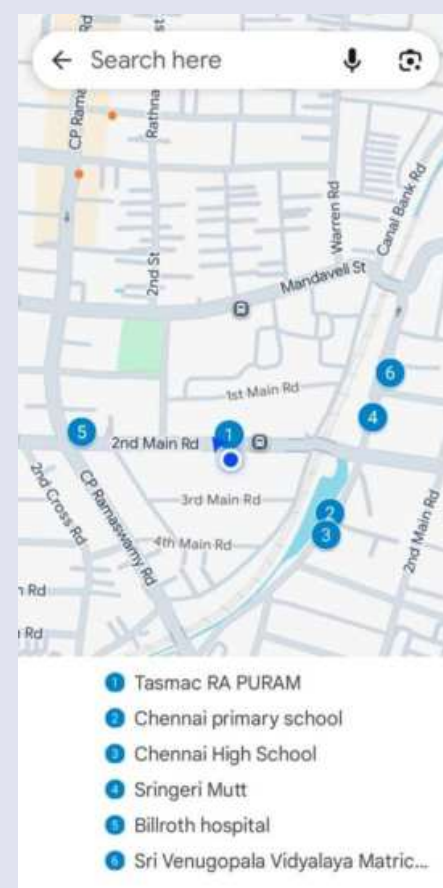
citizens who go to the hospital, clinics, schools, banks and bus terminus have to cross this shop. And they often do so

with fear and insecurity.

Customers of this shop park their vehicles haphazardly on the pavements and roads making these helpless people share the carriageway with motorists.

An accident is waiting to happen at this spot because of this shop. Adding salt to the injury, with the closure of Tasmac shop on Venkatakrishna Road near BSS hospital, more men through this shop caring a hoot about the concerns of residents, pedestrians and vehicular movement. Residents are hopeful the government will close this shop. Anything less than that will be a big disappointment to residents.

*R. Chandrasekaran is founder of RA Puram Residents Association*



# Free waste service for BWGs raises questions

Here are some of the posers. Has this move by Greater Chennai Corporation sounded the death knell of in situ composting? Are bulk waste generators being divested of their responsibility? Will this decision put waste management infrastructure under greater strain?



File photo of an awareness rally conducted by Greater Chennai Corporation and Urbaser Sumeet. PHOTO : B. VELANKANNI RAJ

## Quick Fact

A Bulk Waste Generator (BWG) is one who meets any one of the following criteria as per the SWM Rules, 2026

- 100 kg/day** - Waste generation
- 20,000 sq.m** - Built-up area
- 40,000 litres/day** - Water usage

LIFFY THOMAS

**W**ith Greater Chennai Corporation authorising private conservancy operators, Ramky and Urbaser Sumeet, to collect waste from bulk generators at no fee, has the city's push for in-situ composting taken a backseat?

The Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026 that came into effect on April 1, 2026 requires all bulk waste generators to process wet waste in-situ or obtain an Extended Bulk Waste Generator Responsibility certificate stating that on-site processing is not feasible. Bulk waste generators are those who produce more than 100 kilos of waste a day or have a built-up area of 20,000 sq.m or consume 40,000 litres of water a day.

This should have ideally been an opportunity for municipal corporations and panchayats to push bulk waste generators such as large gated communities, sprawling IT parks and big commercial buildings to treat maximum amount of biodegradable waste at source or at least push them to find ways to create space

to start composting in a small way.

GCC authorised Ramky and Urbaser Sumeet to collect waste from bulk generators as it was receiving many complaints of illegal dumping of waste in public spaces by some vendors who collect waste. Some bulk waste generators have also been unable to find the right vendors to dispose of the waste.

Other vendors in this business say Chennai has inadequate infrastructure to process the collected waste. The many micro composting centres that once thrived have reduced in number.

Mahmood Sait, CEO, Urbaser Sumeet, says if a property does not have space then it is better that government takes up.

Urbaser Sumeet collects all kinds of waste including hazardous waste if a community does not have its own treatment centre, but insists people segregate and hand it over to them in a specific bin.

"Earlier every bulk waste generator had to pay a vendor to do this; now they are not being charged but must give the waste to authorised concessionaires and we are responsible for zones

IX to XV," says Sait. Ramky is in charge of Zones I to V.

Since the new changes came into effect, Urbaser Sumeet is getting 40% of waste from bulk generators.

"Some have refused to give us the waste as they want an order from GCC. We have a list of apartment and commercial buildings that are not handing it to our team and we are discussing this with GCC," says Sait.

Certain resident associations might be happy that they are saving money with the new system, but communities that have sustainable waste management practices hope the arrangement does not undo the good work they have done over the years.

Sumitha Iyer, waste segregation team, The Central Park South and committee lead, FOMRRA Swachh Bharat, says the new system is yet to pass muster among residents.

Central Park South in Sholinganallur, for instance, follows the practice of weighing the waste it generates before sending it out. Its organic waste vendor was selected after frequent checks of the composting site. It slaps a fine on residents who do

not hand over segregated waste.

"We have built trust over the years with the vendor by seeing how they do, but we are yet to get the same confidence from the new system," says Sumitha.

She has decided to wait till the end of the month before engaging with Urbaser Sumeet's ground staff. Questions that many environment-conscious residents like her have are: where is the waste being sent? Is the waste getting mixed? How much compost is generated? Can they go and see it?

Geo Damin, former member of Tamil Nadu Solid Waste Management and member of Poovulagin Nanbargal, says decentralised waste management system is the future.

He says, "With the new SWM Rules, GCC should have insisted on on-site composting. This would be cost-effective for the Corporation as it need not spend money on transportation and in finding sites to treat such waste."

Damin also thinks levying a user fee for solid waste management depending on the size of the building could be considered.

## Guide for bulk waste generators

**U**rbaser Sumeet has started distributing a service guide for all bulk waste generators (BWGs). The booklet offers guidelines for proper waste management, explaining what qualifies an entity as bulk waste generator and outlines bin standards, collection timings, grievance redressal and the vehicles used for waste collection. It also insists that its staff should not be paid for services.

To avail its services, a BWG must register on <https://gccservices.in/bulkwaste/register>. The BWG must procure wheeled, labelled and clean bins and move the bins to the main gate before the scheduled collection time.

## Home food from two small joints in Mylapore

BASKAR SESHADRI

**S**rinivasan of Adam Street in Mylapore operates a small catering unit from home. He prepares full lunch every day and those interested can opt for delivery of the same from his place. The pack consists of curry, sambaar, rasam and poriyal; priced at ₹150 without rice and ₹200 with rice. The food is generally ready around 10 a.m. but he wants customers to inform him in advance.

In the evenings, Srinivasan provides hot chappathi for ₹10 per



piece. Apart from this, he prepares mara chekku ennai of all varieties. Srinivasan can be contacted at 98845 08135 and his address is 72 Adam Street, Mylapore (opposite CSI School).

### New eatery

When the mother-daughter duo Shanthi and Vidya tasted success in kitchen business at Madippakkam, they thought of expanding it. And Mylapore was on top of their list. Sri Lucky Bhojan starts around 7.30 a.m. serving hot idlis, pongal, vada and poori.

In the evenings, the kitchen



Srinivasan and (right) at Sri Lucky Bhojan

serves sandwich, momo and fried items. They also serve chapatis, dosa and additionally few items if

needed. The joint is at 21/10, So-laiappan Street Mylapore. Srividya can be reached at 81900 88488.

## 20 extraordinary parents in the spotlight

Sri Arunodayam honours them for their unwavering commitment in raising intellectually disabled children

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

**S**ri Arunodayam's Special Mom Awards brought together families, supporters and distinguished guests at Bharani Studios in Saligramam on May 10 to honour 20 extraordinary parents raising children with intellectual disabilities. This time, a father was among the awardees.

The event was graced by chief guest, S. Govindaraj, Commissioner from the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, along with Justice P. N. Prakash, former judge of the Madras High Court; S. Kumar, District Differently Abled Welfare Officer (Tiruvallur District); S. Thenpandian, Chairperson of the Child Welfare Committee (Tiruvallur District); Srikanth, SP, Crime Against Women and Children (CAW & CW) Wing, Chennai; and T. Srinivasan, President of MEL Systems and Services Ltd.

Children of Sri Arunodayam lit up the stage with joyful performances, which was followed by sharing of powerful stories of courage and determination, offering a deeply moving glimpse into the lives of these families, said a release.

The 20 finalists from Tamil Nadu are Akila Vaidyanathan, Catherine Rathnabai S, Gayathri R,



### Special father wins applause

Fifteen years ago, Velliyamoodu Govindaraj Devaraju's wife passed away leaving him the sole caregiver of two daughters with intellectual disabilities. A daily wage labourer who finds occasional work at farms in Tiruttani, Devaraju faced immense challenges, juggling work and family responsibilities, which include taking care of his daughters Rajeshwari and Mouliswari, now in their late 20's. Devaraju sets out early to work and returns by afternoon to take up chores at home. His relatives stay close by and he asks them to have an eye on his children. Iyyappan Subramaniam, founder and managing trustee of Sri Arunodayam, who visited Devaraju says his application was unique. The judges were impressed with the resilience he demonstrated in bringing up the girls despite facing immense financial difficulties as he does not have any steady income. "Devaraju had trained his children to be somewhat independent," says Iyyappan.

Geetha Varadharajan, Jayanthi T, Jeeva S, Kavitha D, Mahalakshmi V, Manimegalai N U, Meenakshi Kul-karni, Meera Balaji, Rajeshwari Krishnamurthy, Renuga Devi K, Rupavathi R, Sandhya Krishnamoorthy, Sharmila J, Sriharani M, Uma-maheswari S, Vanitha Pushpam O,

and Velliyamoodu Govindaraj Dev-araju. Each awardee received a cash prize of ₹15,000, a certificate, a special trophy, and lifetime free services from Sri Arunodayam. Since 2017, the awards have supported 125 families while continuing to advocate for their rights, ad-



The awardees and (below) Velliyamoodu Govindaraj Devaraju (second from right) being honoured by the dignitaries.

ded the release.

Launched in 2017, the initiative seeks to shine a light on families who choose commitment and dignity in the face of adversity, rather than taking the easier path of abandoning their children. It challenges persistent social stigma and calls

for a more inclusive and compassionate society. Sri Arunodayam, a Chennai-based non-profit dedicated to the care and rehabilitation of abandoned and destitute children with intellectual disabilities, will celebrate 25 years of its journey in 2027.

# Sting operations with a difference

On World Bee Day, meet three residents of Chennai who have established a bond with bees in very different ways: from managing structured frame hives in urban backyards to nurturing colonies on city campuses, and allowing a wild hive to thrive undisturbed in a neem tree at home

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

## Removing bugs, raising bees

For Rajendran Tamilarasam, an IT professional based near Tambaram, beekeeping exists alongside software work, family life and ecological advocacy: a parallel world sustained less by commerce than by fascination. Originally from Mullukurichi village near the foothills of Kolli Hills in Namakkal district, he traces his interest in bees back to childhood memories of accompanying his maternal uncle during honey collection from wild colonies formed on coconut trees. "I would stand below creating smoke while he climbed up to harvest honey," he recalls. Smoke, he explains, temporarily disrupts the bees' scent-based communication system, reducing their ability to signal danger to one another. "This way, both we and the bees stay safe."

Nearly a decade ago, that childhood curiosity gradually evolved into T R Bees and Apiary, a small-scale urban bee farm in Chennai. Operating from the Madambakkam, Rajendran now manages backyard bee colonies while balancing his full-time IT career. Supported closely by his wife, he sells bee colonies to households interested in setting up



hives at home and conducts awareness programmes on pollination, bee behaviour and colony maintenance. Initially, he says, the initiative began as an educational effort aimed at helping people understand how bees contribute to pollination and biodiversity. Over time, increasing public awareness transformed the nature of his work. "Earlier, people immediately called pest control services.

Now many contact us to rescue colonies instead of destroying them," he says. Much of his work in Chennai involves relocating giant hives from apartment buildings and commercial

spaces to safer environments near forested areas. He also trains residents in maintaining backyard hives, inspecting colony health and handling bees safely. Contrary to assumptions about urban spaces being hostile to pollinators, he believes Chennai's mixed vegetation offers bees a surprisingly stable food network throughout the year. "One house may have moringa trees, another ornamental flowers, another coconut or banana plants," he says. "So throughout the year, bees get different nectar sources."

He can be contacted at 99625 91218.

## 'Admissions' on campuses

K. Vasanthakumar moved to Chennai in 2001 after erratic rainfall disrupted farming at his village in Rajapalayam. In the city's dense neighbourhoods, he was quick to notice what others ignored: flowering drumstick trees spilling over compound walls and scattered open plots still capable of sustaining bees. "In those days, areas like Anna Nagar and Arumbakkam had plenty of flowering plants. I felt bees could survive even in a city like Chennai," he says. That instinct deepened in 2006, when he helped a resident in Medavakkam install a bee box that yielded nearly three kilograms of honey within a month. "I was very surprised that we got to eat honey, especially in a city," he recalls. The following year, additional colonies migrated naturally to the area and the yield rose further, convincing him to transport the rest of his bee boxes permanently from his native village to Chennai.

Today, from Kolathur, he runs Amudha Bee Farm, a modest but sustained urban beekeeping initia-

tive rooted in practices inherited from his grandfather. He installs bee colonies in residential compounds, the Guindy horticulture, the Khadi and Village Industries Commission (KVIC) campus in Madhavaram and shaded open spaces with sufficient flowering vegetation. In villages, he explains, colonies form easily near coconut groves and wells. In Chennai, however, survival depends on carefully identifying quieter pockets insulated from traffic, disturbance and excessive heat.

The process begins with a wooden bee box fitted with frames containing worker bees, broods and a queen bee. As the queen lays eggs and the colony expands, overcrowding is prevented by shifting the queen and a few bees into another box, allowing a fresh colony to emerge naturally. Honey extraction, he says, is done carefully using gloves, veils and controlled smoke so that neither the bees nor the honey are harmed. Alongside honey production, Vasanthakumar also prepares small batches of beeswax-based lip balms, face creams and pain balms. "Honey keeps the skin soft and protected, while beeswax locks in moisture naturally," he says, describing them as gentler alternatives to chemical-heavy skin care products.

He supplies bee boxes and live bee colonies on order, along with honey and beeswax-based products. His range of cosmetics includes a 25-gram face cream priced at ₹100 per box and lip balms priced at ₹100 per piece. Yet, despite growing awareness around pollinators, fear continues to influence public attitudes towards bees. "Many people are scared because bees sting. But bees are soft in nature unless they feel threatened," he says. He can be contacted at 99418 68926.



## Summer home stay

Every summer, residents of Nallappa Street in Chromepet begin looking towards a neem tree inside M. Sreedhar's compound that has, over the years, become an unlikely refuge for migrating wild bees. For nearly seven years, colonies have returned to the same branches, building large suspended hives that remain there for



months before dispersing once again.

Unlike conventional beekeepers who manage colonies through wooden frames and controlled extraction, Sreedhar practises a quieter form of stewardship. He does not harvest honey or interfere with the hive. Instead, he simply allows the bees to arrive, inhabit the tree and eventually leave on their own terms.

"For the past six years, every year the bees come, build a nest and stay there for around three to six months depending on the cli-

mate," he says. "The current nest would be the eighth one built here."

This year, however, the bees have been delayed. Sreedhar attributes the absence partly to excessive humidity and increased pesticide spraying in nearby areas. Yet he remains hopeful they will return once conditions improve.

According to him, the bees' repeated migration is closely tied to the environment his family has cultivated around the house. Over the years, they have planted near-

ly 30 native trees within the compound, creating a shaded corridor that supports birds, insects and pollinators alike.

"These are not ordinary bees," he says. "They require a healthy ecosystem. There should not be too much noise, disturbance or harsh sunlight." Far from provoking fear, the colonies have gradually become accepted within the neighbourhood. During one season, residents even switched off exterior lights at night after noticing bees becoming disoriented and dying from the heat.

## A quiet hour



A flock of pigeons perched on a merry-go-round at Marina Beach. PHOTO : VELANKANNI RAJ

## Session on making pickles



Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a workshop on making pickles and pastes on May 21.

Another workshop on making mushrooms will be held on May 22. Both the sessions will be held at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 044 - 29530048.

## MSME training programmes



PHOTO USED FOR REPRESENTATIONAL PURPOSE ONLY.

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME, is conducting a workshop on baking from May 19 to 22. According to a press release, the programme will focus on mak-

ing cookies, pizzas, breads, and cakes from millets, wheat, and heirloom rice varieties.

### Preparation of DPR

The institute is also conducting another workshop

on "Detailed Project Report Preparation" from May 21 to 22. According to a press release, the session will focus on basics of entrepreneurship, market survey, industrial policy of the State, and MSME classification and registration.

Both the programmes will be held from 10 a.m. to 5 p.m. at the institute's premises on SIDCO Industrial Estate, EDII Institute Road, Guindy. Prior registration is mandatory to take part in the programme.

Those above 18 years of age with a minimum educational qualification of class 10 can apply. Air-conditioned hostel facility is available at affordable rates for men and women on first come, first serve basis, adds the release. Phone: 8668102600 / 87544 95254.



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## A Made-in-India vehicle toy range

Funskool India Ltd. has launched Blazetrix, a new range of Made-in-India vehicle toys. Under the Blazetrix range, the first line-up of toys is based on the construction theme and has three distinct vehicles: Buzz Claw, Core Crush, and Iron Hook, designed to encourage children to engage in active, immersive play.

Blazetrix combines action-driven designs with interactive features, enabling

children to build, race, and experiment with different play formats, thereby enhancing motor skill development, social interaction, and creativity, said a release.

Designed and manufactured in India, the collection underscores Funskool's focus on local production while adhering to global standards of safety, durability, and product quality, added the release.

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LIFFY THOMAS

**K**ey Performance Indicators (KPIs) might have a corporate ring to it, but is universal, touching every human connection, including that of residents of a gated community with their Management Committee (MC). A gated community in Manapakkam has understood this existential truth, hence an “appraisal” of every member of the MC against their self-imposed goals at the beginning of their term. The committee as a whole is assessed against its promises.

Casagrand Irene Owners Welfare Association (CGIOWA) believes it has set a benchmarks through this system. The framework encourages every member to give their best, and those performing well to get re-elected to the committee.

Spread across 5.6 acres with 295 dwelling units across 15 blocks and 13 villas, this gated community in Alandur Zone (Ward 157) of Greater Chennai Corporation is only seven years old.

#### Solar Power Ninja

Association secretary Lebbaeus Denis's KPI was around going solar. With flats ranging from 550 sq. ft. to 3500 sq. ft., the social profile of residents is varied, making buy-in a challenge. After multiple meetings, rooftop solar installation took off in three phases.

“Our 300 KWp rooftop solar project today powers the entire community's common areas including lifts, air conditioners in the club house, water pumps, gym, STP, water treatment plant, garden water pumping, street lights, car parking and all common lightings and EV charging stations. TNEB says we are one of the largest in Tamil Nadu's residential segment,” says Denis, who also overseas legal and asset management areas of the community.

Of the ₹1.4 crore invested to implement solar rooftop, CGIOWA took ₹1.25 crore from its corpus

## KPI culture comes home

At Casagrand Irene in Manapakkam, every member of the managing committee elected by residents is assessed by key performance indicators established for them



and the rest from the revenue streams it generates.

“Our annual electricity bill from the common areas generates over 5.13 lakh unit that translates to ₹ 60 lakh. We have begun to see solar PVC as a significant return on the investment we made,” says the secretary.

Currently, only 25% of rooftop terrace has solar panels and the rest of the space is available for future expansion of the solar initiative.

Casagrand Irene has brought out a brochure detailing the process and features: how the Association selected M/s Tamilnadu Energy System as vendor; technical specifications of solar panels and inverter; the break-up of electricity charges. With a message from former MLA T.M. Anbarasan, the brochure was distributed to close to 100 communities in the constituency.

#### Mr. Keep It Clean

Early this year, a team from Urbaser Sumeet documented best practices in waste management being adopted by the community. The architect of this system is said to be Karthikeyan M., assisted by his wife, Alagu K. The couple had moved in from Adyar, where they were part of many door-to-door drives by Residents of Kasturba Nagar (ROKA).

“In my KPI, I had promised to make the community zero waste,” says Karthikeyan, joint secretary overseeing housekeeping operations and waste management. He maintains a tracking mechanism that shows how they collect and monitor waste on a daily and monthly basis.

Over the last six months, for instance, “black plastic cover” used to line garbage bins for wet waste disposal has been reduced from 591 kg to zero kg, thereby prevent-

ing plastic waste from going to dumping grounds.

The society also has an organic waste converter and is planning to procure more. “Waste management initiatives at the community are only four years old and we are taking baby steps. We hope to follow the three Rs with the support of residents, housekeeping staff and Urbaser Sumeet,” says Karthikeyan who works with an MNC.

Lebbaeus Denis says CGIOWA functions like a mini-corporate, every process is documented and there is an induction programme before a new committee takes over.

#### The Water Evangelist

For president Senthil Jagadeesan, interest lies in water. He oversees water conservation initiatives including ensuring runoffs go into the 75 recharge pits in the society and grey water is used in garden and for landscape.

Magesh Giri, joint secretary, also shares the ‘department’ with Sen-

▼ An assembly of managing committee members; and a view of the villas.

PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

thil, overseeing garden and water management.

Ashok Premesh, treasure, is in-charge of revenue management including compliance. Karthikeyan A.S., vice-president, oversees the security and parking management. Likewise, Govarthan, an assistant director in the film industry, was brought into the committee seeing the diversity he would bring to the table. Every Pongal, the society turns into a mini-village under his supervision. Denis says funds is not a constraints for MC members to function effectively. “We go all out to give them what they want and they do perform,” says Denis, a serial entrepreneur. “We have different revenue streams to generate funds. For instance, last year we opened a studio flat with all star facilities. By paying ₹2,000 a day, a resident can use it to accommodate a guest,” he says.

Of the 17 SDG goals, Denis says, the community has ticked seven goals required for community living, and has set its sights on other goals. It is working on getting ISO and LEED certifications.

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